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MIXING

Preparing Files for Mixing

Essential guidelines for organizing and preparing your multitrack files for professional mixing.

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2026

A clean mix starts with clean files.

> To ensure the best possible result when sending your project for mixing, it's important that everything is well-organized, properly labeled, and exported in a format that gives the mixing engineer full flexibility. Below you'll find a detailed checklist and explanations to help you prepare your session for mixing. If any questions should arise, feel free to get a hold of me either via mail or phone.

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1. Exporting Your Tracks

Consolidate All Tracks

Every audio file should start from **bar 1 (or 00:00:00)** — even if the actual sound comes in later. This ensures that when all the files are imported into a new session, everything lines up perfectly.

Good example:
A vocal harmony that only plays in the chorus is still exported as a full-length file, starting at bar 1.

Bad example:
A vocal harmony stem that starts exactly when the part comes in. This will cause alignment issues.

> Tip: Most DAWs have a “consolidate” or “bounce in place” feature for this.

Clear and Consistent Track Naming

Use clear, descriptive names for each stem. This saves time and avoids confusion for the mix engineer.

Recommended format:
`Instrument_Role_Position`

Examples:

- `LeadVox_Main`
- `Guitar_RhythmL`
- `Guitar_RhythmR`
- `Kick`
- `SnareTop`
- `SnareBottom`
- `BassDI`

- `BassAmp`
- `Synth_Arp`
- `BV_StackL`, `BV_StackR`

Avoid default names like `Audio_01.wav` or `Track5.wav`.

Print Dry Tracks (No Effects)

Unless a specific effect is absolutely essential to the sound or the vibe (for example, a chorus on a synth or a creative vocal delay), export your tracks dry:

- No EQ
- No compression
- No reverb or delay

If you're unsure whether an effect should be kept or removed, you can send both a dry and a wet version, clearly labeled (e.g. `LeadVox_Main_Dry.wav` and `LeadVox_Main_Wet.wav`).

Audio File Format

- **Format:** WAV (or AIFF if needed)
- **Bit Depth:** 24-bit (or higher if recorded that way)
- **Sample Rate:** 44.1 kHz or 48 kHz (match your session settings)
- Do not send MP3 files unless there is no other option

Lossy files like MP3 reduce audio quality and can negatively affect the final mix.

2. Session Information & Extras

Provide a Tempo Map or BPM

Let your mix engineer know the BPM (tempo) of the track. If your song includes tempo changes, export and include a tempo map or a MIDI file with tempo automation.

Example:
"The track is in 6/8 at 90 BPM throughout."

Include a Reference Mix

Always include a rough mix of your track — even if it's not polished. This gives your engineer an idea of:

- How you envision the balance
- Panning ideas
- Effects usage
- Vocal placement

Label it clearly, for example: `TrackName_RoughMix.wav`.

Add Notes If Needed

If there are parts that need special attention (or things you're unsure about), include a short text file or an email with notes such as:

- "The vocals in the bridge need tuning."
- "The guitar solo is meant to sound raw."
- "Let me know if you think the harmonies are too loud."

More context always leads to a better result.

Keep It Simple

Don't send full DAW projects unless requested. Engineers often work in a different DAW than you, so audio files (WAVs) are the universal standard.

Example folder structure:

```
/TrackName_MixPrep/
├── Audio Stems/
│   ├── LeadVox_Main.wav
│   ├── LeadVox_Doubles.wav
│   ├── Guitar_RhythmL.wav
│   └── ...
├── TrackName_RoughMix.wav
├── TrackNotes.txt
└── BPM_TempoMap.mid
```

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3. Final Checklist

- ☐ All files start at bar 1 and are the same length
- ☐ Tracks are clearly named
- ☐ Effects removed unless essential
- ☐ 24-bit WAV, 44.1/48 kHz
- ☐ Rough mix included
- ☐ BPM and notes provided